Its military action, not US intervention, was the main catalyst for Pakistan to ask for ceasefire. But Munir has gained too by wrapping the Pakistan flag around himself and claiming to be the true defender of its sovereignty while also internationalising Kashmir once again."

What to Expect Next

Most experts see the current truce as a tenuous one. With none of the key issues between the two countries resolved yet, there is every chance of a resumption of hostilities. As Modi himself said, "We have just suspended our retaliatory action against Pakistan's terror and military camps. In the coming days, we will measure every step by the criterion of the attitude Pakistan adopts going ahead." Operation Sindoor, an official remarks, "has been paused, it has not ended." Meanwhile, news channels had Modi government sources saying that it had decided that, from now on, every terror strike in India would be treated as an act of war. While it is not clear whether that is official policy now, it is a risky strategy that could have India caught in a militaristic frame when it should be focusing more on economic growth and beefing up its intelligence and surveillance networks to thwart terror strikes. Michael Kugelman, a US-based South Asia specialist, says, "We have a very fragile peace in place. The core drivers of this crisis and those before it have not been dealt with. That includes terror, it includes Kashmir, and the deeper levels of tension between the two, with increasingly sophisticated weapons and technology being used against each other. The crisis shows that the two countries are primed for another round of hostilities, sooner rather than later."

WITH PAKISTAN'S ECONOMY IN TATTERS, INDIA NEEDS TO BUILD A COALITION OF NATIONS, INCLUDING THE USA AND SAUDI ARABIA, TO PRESSURE PAKISTAN VIA INSTRUMENTS SUCH AS THE IMF

The Modi government is aware of the risks and has instructed the three services to be on full alert. Each of them has begun evaluating the outcome of the war, and assessing their strengths and weaknesses. India also knows Pakistan is doing the same and deduces it will persuade China and Turkey to strengthen its ability to combat India's air power since it knows it cannot match its naval prowess. The possibility that India may have to take on adversaries on two fronts and that China may pump arms into Pakistan in the event of another bout of war continues to be of grave concern to India. This might neutralise any military superiority that India may have over Pakistan, and enable the latter to hold out against India as Ukraine has been able to do against Russia thanks to the constant stream of arms supplies from the US and Europe. India also has to work on improving its space-based surveillance and electronic warfare—areas in which China excels.

It is also clear that having targeted terror outfits in which JeM chief Masood Azhar's kin have been killed, India can expect them to regroup for a big strike. It is worrying that India has not been able to nab the Pahalgam perpetrators even three weeks after the incident. Harsh Shringla, former foreign secretary, says, "We need to focus on our intelligence and security apparatus and enhance those capabilities. To bring tourists back to Kashmir and defeat the aims of these terror groups, we need to ensure foolproof protection. We must also have a mechanism for a graded response to such attacks. So, higher the level, higher the response." This is essential as India needs to focus on getting massive investments to fund its ambitious economic growth targets. Frequent hostilities would breed an uncertainty, which will be detrimental to India's larger interests.

To avert another blow-up, it's important that Pakistan keeps the LoC free of conflict and works towards restoring the ceasefire agreement that was in place since 2021 before the Pahalgam attack shattered it. Many experts believe that India focuses on dealing with the problems created by Pakistan, and not dealing with the Pakistan problem. Sharat Sabharwal, a former Indian high commissioner to Pakistan, though, believes that it is a futile exercise. "If a crushing defeat in the 1971 war couldn't change the nature of Pakistan, you think a four-day war will? Strategically, our endeavour should be to bring them down to a point where we can have a constructive engagement with them. It's a distant goal, but good diplomacy may craft out something." According to him, despite army chief Munir consolidating his hold, many in Pakistan feel that their country should be focusing on economic growth and well-being instead of terror. With Pakistan's economy in tatters and surviving on intermittent tranches from the International Monetary Fund, Sabharwal suggests that India find other ways of putting pressure on Pakistan to behave. Shringla recommends that apart from the US, India could work through Saudi Arabia, whom Pakistan listens to, and build an informal international coalition that nudges Islamabad out of its bad old ways.

India-Pakistan relations have always been somewhat of a roller-coaster ride, with unexpected twists and turns. Who thought the war would end so quickly just when it seemed headed for a no-holds-barred conflict? Sometimes, the unexpected can be a positive too—that is the only silver lining to the dark clouds that continue to hover over the subcontinent. ■